

2026 Comparative Politics Comprehensive Exam

Day 1: Core

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August 22, 2026

Question

What array of causal drivers are adduced in the literature to account for different political outcomes in regime type, state form or electoral systems (i.e. dictatorship vs democracy; contrasting cleavage structures; electoral systems). How do theorists deploy history and timing in making their arguments?

Introduction

From the peninsula of Gibraltar,¹ one can see land governed by three distinct states: the Kingdom of Spain, the Kingdom of Morocco, and the United Kingdom.² The landscape is visually quite similar; the boundary between Gibraltar and Spain is purely political, and the seven-mile-wide strait is geologically little more than an advanced valley. Yet, each of these lands has experienced dramatically distinct transitions – or lack thereof – from monarchy to democracy. Spain’s development to liberal democracy famously included an extensive fascist dictatorship; the United Kingdom’s gradual progression to the current Westminster System was significantly more gradual; Morocco is still a monarchy today, even if with some modest constitutional restrictions. Why, then, does this one coastal viewpoint offer such a distinct range of political outcomes across a relatively undistinctive physical landscape?

Identifying political and economic deviations across meager physical boundaries is not a novel perspective within political science or the social sciences more generally; Acemoglu & Robinson (2012) famously employ this framework to counter theories of economic dependence on geographical factors in “Why Nations Fail.” Yet, the question is still an intriguing one that has motivated a significant corner of the social sciences, perhaps none more significantly than comparative politics. By Mill’s (1843) “method of difference,” the relatively identical nature of this physical landscape, compared to the significant variation in sociopolitical outcomes, suggests that the causal factors behind regime outcomes must lie elsewhere. If geography

¹So long as one’s southward view is not entirely obscured by the titular Rock

²Of which Gibraltar is an “Overseas Territory”

alone does not sufficiently explain the distinction between the human-created institutions built upon them, then it indeed must be the case that the driving factors are, to a large extent, humanistic themselves.

In this response, I explore the literature's fundamental discussions of the factors driving political outcomes in regime type, state form, and broadly, political institutions. I present three primary causal arguments, each of which is unique in its approach but not mutually exclusive from the others: (1) a state's historical economic composition and structure; (2) the identity-based composition of the constituency, along with the salience of those identity characteristics; and (3) the chronological timing of modernization processes themselves. I further present a relatively – though admittedly not entirely – conflicting counterargument regarding the innate dependency of political outcomes on randomized or exogenous influences, discussing both its limitations and its possible contributions nonetheless. I close by exploring some various empirical strategies that could be used to further our collective perception of these three (or four) causal relationships. **rewrite this – explore existing and present further**

In discussing and evaluating these arguments, I do not intend to provide a definitive weighting of their relative accuracy or value. To do so would be more than I could hope to reasonably accomplish in an entire career, and would almost certainly involve discarding valuable arguments that may indeed be foundational. Yet, I do explore my own perspectives within these frameworks, largely built upon my personal affinity towards rationalist and institutionalist answers. It is our responsibility as social scientists to pursue those narratives which we believe most effectively explain the world around us, and to consider how those

mechanisms might be best employed to construct a more effective political future.

An Economic Explanation

References

- Acemoglu, Daron & James A. Robinson. 2012. *Why Nations Fail: The Origins of Power, Prosperity, and Poverty*. New York: Crown Business.
- Mill, John Stuart. 1843. *A System of Logic, Ratiocinative and Inductive*. Vol. I New York: Harper & Brothers. Chapter 8, Volume I assigned; orig. pub. 1843.